

LECCE — THE STONE AND THE BAROQUE

Voice: Pietro, 63 years old, stonemason, fourth generation

LECCE — THE STONE AND THE BAROQUE

Voice: Pietro, 63 years old, stonemason, fourth generation

CAP. 1 — INTRO: THE FIRST FACADE

Look at that facade.

Don't walk past. Look.

Angels, acanthus leaves, volutes, twisted columns, figures emerging from the stone as if they're about to walk away. And all of this is made of stone. Not marble — Lecce stone. The stone from here.

My name is Pietro. I'm sixty-three years old and my hands have been white with tufa dust since I was fifteen. My father was a stonemason, my grandfather was a stonemason, my grandfather's father was a stonemason. Fourth generation.

I know Lecce from the wrong side of the facades — the side you don't see, the side you're facing when you're holding the chisel. I know where the stones have cracked, where the post-war restorers used the wrong cement, where a capital was remade in the 1960s and you can tell it's not original.

Lecce is not the Florence of the South. That's what journalists write. Lecce is Lecce — a city built on a particular stone by particular people in a particular time. And the result is unique in the world.

CAP. 2 — LECCE STONE: THE SECRET OF EVERYTHING

Before we talk about churches and palaces, I need you to understand the stone.

Lecce stone is a soft limestone. It's called carparo, or pietra leccese, and it's made mostly of fragments of marine fossils — shells, corals, sea urchins — deposited here when Salento was underwater sixty million years ago.

It's soft when you quarry it. It cuts almost like wood. You can carve tiny details, thin curves, smooth surfaces that look like skin. You can't do that with marble — marble chips, it has a different grain. Lecce stone obeys you.

Then, over time, it oxidises. It hardens. The colour shifts from white-grey when freshly cut to the warm yellow you see on old facades — that colour that turns gold at sunset.

Lecce is baroque not just because it was rich in the 1600s. It's baroque because it had this stone. Without the carparo, Lecce baroque wouldn't exist. They would have built something simpler, like everywhere else. But here they could carve everything, and they carved everything.

CAP. 3 — SANTA CROCE: THE FACADE OF CENTURIES

Now go and stand in front of the Basilica of Santa Croce.

Stop about twenty metres back. Far enough to see the whole facade.

What you're looking at is the work of three centuries and at least five different sculptors. Work began in 1549 and finished in 1695. A hundred and forty-six years. Generations of stonemasons passing the same project from father to son.

Look at the central doorway. Columns with shafts wrapped in vines and leaves. In the broken tympanum above the door, a Triumph of the Celestine Order with allegorical figures, chained Turks, symbols of Christian victory. The balcony on the second floor is held up by telamones — male figures bearing the weight of the structure on their shoulders, each with a different expression.

I worked on this facade in 1998. Restoring a section of the upper cornice. Three months on scaffolding twenty metres up. From that distance you see things you'd never imagine from below — details of leaves and figures finished with incredible care, in spots where nobody would ever see them. Whoever did that work didn't do it to be seen. They did it because that was how it was done.

CAP. 4 — PIAZZA DEL DUOMO: THE ENCLOSED SQUARE

Now come with me to a place many visitors don't find straight away.

Go through the arch at the end of Via Vittorio Emanuele II and stop.

Piazza del Duomo is a closed square. It doesn't open onto other streets — you enter through the arch and you're inside. The Cathedral, the Bell Tower, the Bishop's Palace and the Seminary form an almost complete enclosure.

That choice isn't accidental. In the Middle Ages and the Renaissance, the bishop's square needed to be separate from the city, controllable, defensible. The arch was the gate. At night it was locked.

The Bell Tower is 70 metres tall and is the vertical element visible from all over the city. Built in 1661, it was designed to be seen from far away — from the countryside, from the coast, by travellers. "You're in Lecce," the tower said. "You've arrived."

The Cathedral facade is on the side, not the front — unusual for a cathedral. Because there wasn't enough space in front to stand back and look at it. So they built it on the flank, where there was more room to breathe.

Practical solution, beautiful result. Often the best things come from a problem.

CAP. 5 — THE ROMAN AMPHITHEATRE: TWO THOUSAND YEARS UNDER THE SQUARE

Walk toward Piazza Sant'Oronzo.

What you see in the centre of the square, sunk below current street level, is a Roman amphitheatre from the second century AD. It could hold between twenty-five and forty thousand spectators. Almost completely buried under the modern city.

Lecce is called *Lupiae* in Latin. It was an important Roman city — on the Appian Way, with a theatre, amphitheatre, baths, forum. Then came the Normans, then the Aragonese, then the Bourbons, and every time something new was built it was built on top of what came before.

The amphitheatre was discovered in 1901 during construction work for the Bank of Italy. Work stopped. Excavation began. And gradually it emerged that under Piazza Sant'Oronzo lay this enormous structure.

Today less than a third of it is visible. The rest is still beneath the buildings around the square — under bars, under shops, under the streets. Every now and then, when work is done, a piece of seating emerges, a fragment of mosaic. The city keeps surprising itself.

CAP. 6 — CARTAPESTA: LECCE'S OTHER ART

There's something else Lecce does better than anyone, and most visitors don't know it.

Cartapesta — papier-mâché.

Not carnival papier-mâché, light and colourful. Lecce cartapesta is different — sacred figures, nativity scenes, statues of saints made from paper and glue with such precision they look like wood or terracotta.

The technique was born in the 1600s, in parallel with the architectural baroque. Cartapesta was the poor man's material — you couldn't afford marble, but you could make beautiful statues with paper, glue and ingenuity. The rural churches filled with saints and madonnas in cartapesta that you can't recognise as such up close.

Today there are still workshops in Lecce using the same techniques as the 1600s. Finding a workshop open to visitors and watching how it's done is one of the most interesting things you can do in this city. Better than any museum.

CAP. 7 — HISTORY IN BRIEF: HOW LECCE BECAME WHAT IT IS

Lecce has two thousand seven hundred years of documented history. I'm not going to tell you all of it — just the parts you can still see.

The Messapians were here before the Romans. An Italic people who occupied Salento and resisted romanisation for a long time. Of the Messapian period the walls remain — you can see a section in the Belloluogo Park, large blocks of Lecce stone dating to four, five hundred years before Christ.

The Romans built the modern city — roads, amphitheatre, theatre. Then the Normans in the eleventh century brought order and Romanesque churches. Then Aragon in the fifteenth century, and with them came the Renaissance.

The seventeenth century is Lecce's century. The Spanish viceroyalty brought wealth, the great noble families built palaces and churches, and that specific baroque emerged — the Lecce baroque — that you find nowhere else on earth.

It's not the Roman baroque of Bernini. It's not Venetian baroque. It's something different — fleshier, denser, as if the stone decided to explode.

CAP. 8 — THE LIVING CITY: THE UNIVERSITY AND THE EVENINGS

Lecce is not a museum.

It's a city of a hundred thousand people with a large university, an old centre where real people live, bars and shops open late.

The University of Salento was founded in 1955 and today has forty thousand enrolled students. That means for eight months of the year the streets of the centre are full of students. This presence completely changes the atmosphere — there are bookshops, cafes, nightlife in the middle of baroque palaces.

Evenings in Lecce are particular. The passeggiata along Corso Vittorio Emanuele II starts around six and goes until eight. It's a serious thing — you go to see and be seen,

you greet people, you meet people, you catch up on news. This habit has survived even with phones in hand.

In summer Lecce empties during the day and fills at night. Those who can go to the sea — Gallipoli forty minutes away, the beaches at Castro, at Otranto. Then in the evening they come back. That's Salento life — the sea is close but you don't live there, you go and come back.

CAP. 9 — WHAT TO EAT: THE PASTICCIOTTO AND THE REST

The pasticciotto.

If you leave Lecce without having eaten at least one warm pasticciotto, you've done something wrong.

It's a shortcrust pastry filled with custard cream, baked in the oven, oval shaped. You eat it in the morning, warm, with caffè leccese.

Caffè leccese is espresso with almond milk and ice. You don't order a frappuccino in Lecce — you order caffè leccese. In summer it's how you survive the heat.

The rustico leccese is a puff pastry disc filled with béchamel, tomato and mozzarella. You find it in every bakery. It's cheap, filling, the breakfast-lunch-snack of half of Lecce.

For lunch or dinner, look for pitta di patate — a savoury potato and onion pie that's peasant food turned speciality. And ciceri e tria — semolina pasta with chickpeas, half the pasta boiled and half fried. Two cooking methods in the same bowl. Invented out of necessity, now tradition.

CAP. 10 — SALENTO: LECCE AS A GATEWAY

One thing you need to know.

Lecce is the gateway to Salento — not the whole of Salento.

Salento is the heel of the boot, that peninsula ending between the Ionian and Adriatic seas. Lecce is the main city, but around it are places worth as much as Lecce itself.

Otranto is fifty-five kilometres away — the easternmost city in Italy, with a Norman cathedral that has the largest medieval mosaic floor in the world.

Gallipoli is forty kilometres away — a city on an island connected to the mainland by a bridge, with a labyrinthine old centre and some of the best beaches in Puglia.

Castro, Specchia, Tricase, Nardò — baroque towns like Lecce but without the tourists, where the old centre is still everyday life.

If you have two days, use Lecce as a base and explore. If you only have one day, stay in the city. There's enough.

CAP. 11 — PRACTICAL ADVICE: WHEN AND HOW

The heat.

July and August in Lecce are serious. Forty degrees, humidity, no shade on the flagstone squares. The churches become your best friend — you go in not for devotion but for the coolness of the stone.

The best time is May-June and September-October. The light is beautiful, the temperature is liveable, there are fewer tourists. The baroque facades at sunset in October have an orange-gold colour you don't forget.

Churches open and close unpredictably. Many close from noon to four. If you want to see Santa Croce from inside, go early morning or late afternoon.

The old centre is walkable. Everything that matters is within walking distance. Leave the car outside the bastions and walk — Lecce is seen by looking up, not by watching the navigation screen.

CAP. 12 — CLOSING: PIETRO SAYS GOODBYE

Sixty-three years with a chisel.

I've seen many cities — for work, for restorations, for conferences. Venice, Rome, Palermo, Naples. All beautiful.

None of them has this stone.

The carparo is the reason Lecce is what it is. Not money, not kings, not bishops. The stone. A stone that let itself be carved, that turned yellow with the years, that didn't crack under the chisel.

My colleagues in Rome work with travertine — beautiful, noble, but hard. Those in Venice work with Istrian stone — white, compact. I work with carparo. And when I walk into a Lecce church and look up, I know exactly how long every leaf took, every scroll, every angel.

You don't rush it. You don't improvise. You do it with patience, with respect for the material, with the knowledge that what you make must last after you're gone.

Lecce lasts. After two thousand seven hundred years, it still lasts.

Enjoy the city. Look up. Always.